

openhouse

art & design · ages 5-8

the artiverse book

the art we make – and why



a teacher's companion to every artwork · 8 units

why these artworks – in this order

Every artwork here is a **real piece by a working artist**, chosen because it teaches a specific **skill** through a technique a child can genuinely do. The units run **easiest → hardest**, each carries a **medium symbol**, and together they cover the five spiral skills.

	 oil pastel	 watercolour	 mixed media	
1	 whimsical sun oil pastel			C&P I&C ●●○○○
2	 star with a face oil pastel			C&P I&C ●●○○○
3	 fish oil pastel			S&F C&P ●●●○○
4	 two fish oil pastel			S&F B&C ●●●○○
5	 sea creatures watercolour			C&P S&F ●●●○○
6	 whimsical creature mixed media			S&F I&C ●●●○○
7	 eric carle bird painted-paper collage			C&P B&C I&C ●●●○○
8	 pigeon collage mixed media			S&F B&C ●●●○○

skills across the book: line & texture · shape & form · colour & painting · balance & composition · imagination & collaboration – revisited at rising difficulty (the spiral).

whimsical sun

oil pastel

the objective

Blend warm colours smoothly inside one shape, and give a familiar object a face and a feeling.

skills it builds

colour & painting

imagination & collaboration

the technique

Layering & blending oil pastel – press light first, then hard; blend where two colours meet with a fingertip; add the little face last.

1. Draw the sun's round shape and its face.
2. Fill with yellow, pressing harder at the rays.
3. Blend orange into the yellow; add the face and cheeks last.

why it's good for children

Oil pastel gives **instant, rich colour** with almost no skill barrier, so children feel successful straight away. Blending by hand teaches that colours **become** new colours through what the hand does – and giving the sun a face turns a colour exercise into a small act of feeling.

how to encourage them

Ask “*what mood is your sun in today?*” Model one blend, then step back – never correct a colour.

materials

oil pastels · cartridge paper

where it sits in the spiral

the book's warm, confident start – blending returns in every colour unit.



what we make – a sun with its own face

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► artist's instagram reel – credit to be added

topic options: a sleepy morning sun · a cheeky sun · a proud summer sun

star with a face

oil pastel

the objective

Blend cool colours inside a shape and bring it to life with a character.

skills it builds

colour & painting

imagination & collaboration

the technique

Blending & character – fill the star with blended blues and greens, then add a face and cheeks to give it personality.

1. Draw a bold star shape.
2. Fill and blend cool colours inside it.
3. Add a face, cheeks and tiny details last.

why it's good for children

Repeating the blending idea on a new shape **consolidates the skill**, while a character keeps it joyful. Children learn that the same technique makes many different things.

how to encourage them

"What kind of star is this – brave? sleepy?" Celebrate personality over neatness.

materials

oil pastels · paper

where it sits in the spiral

revisits blending from the sun, now with cool colours.



what we make – a starry little character

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► artist's instagram reel – credit to be added

topic options: a happy star · a shy star · a shooting star with a face

fish

oil pastel

the objective

Draw a fish from one simple shape and layer colours for a shimmery surface.

skills it builds

shape & form

colour & painting

the technique

Shape + shimmer – build the body from one pointed oval, layer blue, silver and yellow, and blend for iridescence; add marks for scales.

1. Draw one pointed oval for the body.
2. Layer blue, silver and yellow and blend for shimmer.
3. Press short marks for scales; add the eye and fins.

why it's good for children

A fish is a forgiving 'real' subject – one simple shape a child draws with confidence, which frees their attention for **colour**. Chasing the shimmer of a real fish makes children close observers.

how to encourage them

Put a real fish photo out – “*how many colours hide in one scale?*”

materials

oil pastels · paper · a fish photo

where it sits in the spiral

shape confidence built here supports the composition of the next unit.



what we make – one shimmering fish

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► artist's instagram reel – credit to be added

topic options: a big fish · a fish from the market · a rainbow fish

two fish

oil pastel

the objective

Overlap two fish so they swim together – an early taste of composition and depth.

skills it builds

shape & form

balance & composition

the technique

Overlap & composition – draw one fish, then a second that crosses it, so one appears in front of the other.

1. Draw the first fish.
2. Add a second that overlaps it.
3. Colour both, keeping the front one clear.

why it's good for children

Overlapping quietly introduces **composition and depth** without ever naming it – children discover that where things sit changes the picture.

how to encourage them

"Let them swim together – which one is in front?"

materials

oil pastels · paper

where it sits in the spiral

turns single-shape confidence into a first real composition.



what we make – two fish swimming together

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► artist's instagram reel – credit to be added

topic options: two fish · a small shoal · fish crossing paths

sea creatures

watercolour

the objective

Paint several simple sea creatures with bright washes to build a whole scene.

skills it builds

colour & painting

shape & form

the technique

Bright washes + simple shapes – build each creature from an easy shape and fill with clean, bright watercolour.

1. Sketch a few sea creatures as simple shapes.
2. Fill each with a bright watercolour wash.
3. Add legs, eyes and pattern once dry.

why it's good for children

Watercolour gives lively, luminous colour, and simple creatures let children build a **full scene** – their first taste of composing many elements on one page.

how to encourage them

"Who lives in your sea?" Encourage a busy, colourful world.

materials

watercolours · thick paper

where it sits in the spiral

composing several elements; a bridge toward the collage scenes ahead.



what we make – a lively underwater world

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► artist's instagram reel – credit to be added

topic options: a crab and an octopus · a rock pool · a coral reef

whimsical creature

mixed media

the objective

Invent a creature by combining bold shapes, pattern and colour.

skills it builds

shape & form

imagination & collaboration

the technique

Shape play + pattern – build a creature from simple shapes, then fill it with your own patterns and marks.

1. Build a creature from a few bold shapes.
2. Fill it with your own patterns.
3. Add eyes and details to bring it alive.

why it's good for children

Inventing frees **imagination** to lead – there's no wrong answer, which builds creative confidence, while filling with pattern grows fine control.

how to encourage them

"The sillier the better – what does yours do?"

materials

pens · oil pastel · paper

where it sits in the spiral

invention + pattern; sets up the collage creatures that follow.



what we make – an invented creature

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► artist's instagram reel – credit to be added

topic options: a friendly monster · a magic fish · a creature no one has seen

eric carle bird

painted-paper collage

the objective

Paint textured paper, then tear and layer it to build a bird (Eric Carle's method).

skills it builds

colour & painting

balance & composition

imagination & collaboration

the technique

Painted-paper collage – paint whole sheets with texture, dry them, then tear shapes and layer them into a bird.

1. Paint several sheets in bright textures.
2. Once dry, tear body, wing and tail shapes.
3. Layer and glue them into a bird.

why it's good for children

Separating **making the colour** from **making the picture** lets children work big and bold, then compose calmly – a two-stage process that builds patience and planning.

how to encourage them

Show an Eric Carle spread. *"Fill the whole sheet first."*

materials

paint · paper to paint · glue · scissors

where it sits in the spiral

colour-making meets composition – the book's richest collage.



what we make – a bright bird from painted paper

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► artist's instagram reel – credit to be added

topic options: a parrot · a peacock · a bird of my own

pigeon collage

mixed media

the objective

Build a real bird from cut and torn paper shapes, arranged with care.

skills it builds

shape & form

balance & composition

the technique

Cut-paper composition – build the bird from a body, head, wing and tail cut from paper, arranging before gluing.

1. Cut a body, head, wing and tail.
2. Arrange them into a bird – move before gluing.
3. Glue down and add the eye and feet.

why it's good for children

Building a recognisable bird from separate shapes grows **shape awareness and composition** – children plan how parts fit into a whole.

how to encourage them

"Move the wing until it looks right, then glue."

materials

coloured paper · scissors · glue

where it sits in the spiral

cut-paper composition, a calmer companion to the painted-paper bird.



what we make – a bird built from paper

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► artist's instagram reel – credit to be added

topic options: a city pigeon · a garden bird · a flock